

Basketball Rules and Regulations

Introduction

Basketball is a team sport played between two teams of five players each. The objective is to score points by shooting the ball through the opponent's basket while preventing the opposing team from scoring.

Rule 1: Number of Players

Each team must have five players on the court during play. Teams may have substitute players on the bench who can enter the game during stoppages.

Example

- Team A starts the game with five players.
 - A substitute may replace a player during a timeout.
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Rule 2: Game Duration

A standard basketball game consists of four quarters.

Typical Durations

League Quarter Length

NBA 12 minutes

FIBA 10 minutes

NCAA 20-minute halves

If the score is tied at the end of regulation, overtime periods are played until a winner is determined.

Rule 3: Scoring

Points are awarded based on where the shot is taken.

Point Values

Shot Type	Points
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Free Throw	1
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Field Goal	2
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Three-Point Shot	3
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Example

A player shoots from beyond the three-point line and scores. The team receives three points.

Rule 4: Dribbling

A player must dribble the ball while moving around the court.

Violations

- Double Dribble
- Carrying the Ball
- Traveling

Double Dribble

Occurs when a player:

1. Stops dribbling.
2. Holds the ball.
3. Starts dribbling again.

Penalty: Possession is awarded to the opposing team.

Rule 5: Traveling

A player may not take too many steps without dribbling.

Example

If a player takes three steps without dribbling after gathering the ball, a traveling violation is called.

Penalty: Turnover.

Rule 6: Shot Clock

Teams must attempt a shot within a specified amount of time.

Common Shot Clocks

League Shot Clock

NBA 24 seconds

FIBA 24 seconds

NCAA 30 seconds

Failure to attempt a shot before the shot clock expires results in a turnover.

Rule 7: Personal Fouls

A personal foul occurs when a player makes illegal physical contact with an opponent.

Examples

- Holding
- Pushing
- Blocking
- Hitting

Consequences vary depending on the number of team fouls and shooting situations.

Rule 8: Free Throws

A free throw is an uncontested shot taken from the free-throw line.

Awarded For

- Shooting fouls
- Technical fouls
- Certain penalty situations

Each successful free throw is worth one point.

Rule 9: Out of Bounds

The ball is out of bounds when:

- It touches the boundary line.
- A player holding the ball steps on the boundary line.
- The ball touches an object outside the playing area.

Penalty: Possession is awarded to the opposing team.

Rule 10: Backcourt Violation

After a team advances the ball into the frontcourt, it may not return the ball to the backcourt.

Example

A guard passes the ball into the frontcourt. Another player then sends the ball back into the backcourt where a teammate retrieves it.

Result: Backcourt violation.

Rule 11: Jump Ball

A jump ball is used to begin the game.

In many leagues, possession alternates afterward using the alternating possession rule.

Rule 12: Timeouts

Teams may request timeouts to:

- Discuss strategy
- Rest players
- Stop the game clock

The number and duration of timeouts vary by league.

Rule 13: Technical Fouls

Technical fouls are assessed for unsportsmanlike behavior.

Examples

- Arguing excessively with officials
- Using inappropriate language
- Delaying the game

Penalty:

- Free throws awarded to the opposing team
 - Possible possession of the ball
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Rule 14: Goaltending

Goaltending occurs when a player illegally interferes with a shot on its downward path toward the basket.

Result:

- The basket is awarded to the shooting team.
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Rule 15: Dunking and Basket Interference

Players may dunk the basketball as long as they do not illegally interfere with the rim or basket.

Examples of violations:

- Hanging on the rim unnecessarily
 - Touching the ball while it is directly above the basket cylinder
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Conclusion

Basketball is governed by a set of rules designed to ensure fair play, safety, and competitive balance. Understanding scoring, fouls, violations, and game procedures helps players, coaches, and fans better appreciate the sport.

